



Jared Leto 'Joker' film

The standalone Joker film is happening, hopefully giving Leto a chance to redeem his interpretation. <https://digit.in/jul18-64-1>



Paradox acquires BattleTech

Paradox is to acquire Harebrained schemes, developer of BattleTech and Shadowrun, for \$7.5 million. <https://digit.in/jul18-64-2>

#UnrealInfluence

The world of artificial, CGI influencers is exploding

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It is 2018 and influencers need no introduction. Odds are, you already interact with one on a daily basis in one form or another on social media. Just in case, influencers are the people who have a significant impact on a niche audience due to their credibility, knowledge, appeal or uniqueness. At least they used to be 'people'. In recent times, you might have come across influencers on social media and found that something seems to be a bit off about them, especially their appearance. You might have encountered what is commonly known as a CGI Influencer.

WHAT IS A CGI INFLUENCER

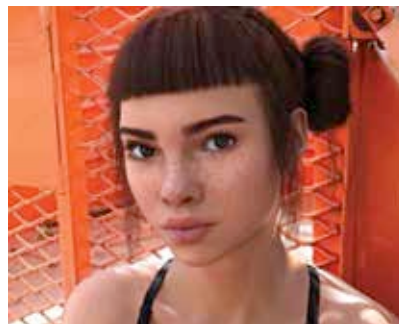
If the name wasn't explanatory enough for you, a CGI influencer isn't a real person. It is a virtual entity created and managed by an individual or a team whose identity is in no way connected to real life counterparts. They exist entirely on the digital realm and often accept the fact boldly. In other aspects, they are exactly like human influencers - they have a significant following, are regular contributors to whichever platform they are on and actually react to real world actions. To be honest, being animated tends to work in their favour.

WHAT WORKS

The story of Miquela Sousa has all the benefits and pitfalls - she started off on Instagram as LilMiquela in 2016

and currently stands as the poster girl of CGI influencers at 1.2mil followers on the platform. Her journey features a healthy dose of controversy as well. Back in April 2018, another CGI personality on Instagram, Bermuda, hacked the account to force Miquela into admitting her fake identity - something that has remained foggy from day one. This forced an LA based startup, Brud, to issue a pretty dubious statement on Miquela's behalf, claiming that she, along with another personality on the platform are AI that they have created.

Putting dubious claims and controversy aside, what was evident from this entire situation is that people were, and are, invested enough in the affairs of artificial influencers. To the point that Miquela has worked with brands like Giphy, Prada and has also sported clothing from Diesel and Moncler. Although she has claimed that none of that content was sponsored, that doesn't mean a demand doesn't exist. Take another example - that of Shudu



Lil Miquela, the poster girl of CGI influencers

Gram, created by fashion photographer Cameron-James Wilson. With her shot to fame coming from a repost by Fenty Beauty, Rihanna's cosmetics brand, she's reportedly received tons of offers for brand sponsored content.

If you are starting to feel that this CGI/virtual influencer madness is

restricted to Instagram, let us quickly dispose of that notion. If you've played EA Sports' Fifa 18, you know Alex Hunter from the Journey mode. You probably also know about the brand endorsement deal that Alex, a virtual



Alex Hunter could be the first in-game virtual ambassador for a real brand

footballer on a meteoric rise to fame, signs with Coca Cola. In fact, Alex signs a similar deal with Adidas as well in the same franchise. Even in video games, this phenomenon transcends genres. Luxury brand Louis Vuitton featured Lightning from Final Fantasy XIII as the ambassador for their Spring/Summer 2016 collection.

WHY DOES IT WORK

These influencers are distinct from mascots that brands sport. Far from being cartoony, they sport distinct personalities and take interest in real world issues. Lil Miquela, in the past, has raised her voice for issues like Black Lives matter and Transgender rights. There's more to their popularity than that.

First off, these influencers are crafted with an ideal image of beauty in mind. Take a look at Lil Miquela and Shudu Gram's Instagram profiles and you'll know what we're talking about. That itself is a popular reason for both brands and followers to flock to these lifelike personas online. On